THE COURAGE ECONOMY

The Lie Catalog

Sixty comfortable lies that keep the Lie Economy running. Named so they can be seen, named so they can be stopped.

LIES ABOUT WORK

01
The Importance Lie
This is really critical/strategic/transformational — it is busywork.

02
The Urgency Lie
We need this by Friday — no one will look at it for weeks.

03
The Impact Lie
This will change how we operate — it will be ignored within months.

04
The Brand Management Lie
Work exists solely to make the department look busy or valuable.

05
The Scope Creep Lie
Just one small addition — knowing it will derail everything.

LIES ABOUT AUTONOMY & INPUT

06
The Consultation Theater Lie
We value your input — the decision is already made.

07
The False Choice Lie
Pick A or B — when C was never an option and you want A.

08
The Empowerment Lie
You have full authority — within pre-approved parameters I have not told you.

09
The Delegation Lie
Own this project — but I will micromanage every decision.

10

The Ownership Lie

This is your call — until I disagree with it.

LIES ABOUT FEEDBACK & PERFORMANCE

11

The Praise Lie

Great job! — it was mediocre at best.

12

The Feedback Withholding Lie

Saying nothing when honest feedback is needed.

13

The Surprise Performance Review Lie

Problems emerge at review time that were never mentioned.

14

The “You’re Doing Fine” Lie

When they are actually on a performance improvement trajectory.

15

The Euphemism Lie

Needs to develop leadership presence — we just do not like them.

LIES ABOUT CREDIT & RECOGNITION

16

The Credit Theft Lie

Presenting others’ work as your own.

17

The Credit Dilution Lie

The team did great work — when one person did 90%.

18

The Invisible Labor Lie

Not acknowledging work that happened.

19

The Visibility Optimization Lie

Presenting only the work that makes you look good.

20

The Contribution Rewrite Lie

I was instrumental in… — you attended two meetings.

LIES ABOUT DECISIONS & DIRECTION

21
The Fait Accompli Lie
Let’s discuss options — already decided and announced.

22
The Data Lie
The data shows… — cherry-picked to support a predetermined conclusion.

23
The Consensus Lie
Everyone agrees — three people agreed, five stayed silent, two disagreed but gave up.

24
The Priority Lie
Everything is top priority — rendering priority meaningless.

25
The Pivot Lie
Strategic shift — we screwed up and are covering.

LIES ABOUT RESOURCES & CONSTRAINTS

26
The Budget Lie
We do not have budget — we do, but not for this or for you.

27
The Timeline Lie
This timeline is fixed — it is arbitrary and will slip.

28
The Constraint Lie
Leadership will not allow it — I have not asked or do not want to.

29
The Capacity Lie
We do not have bandwidth — we have it, but not for your thing.

30
The Headcount Lie
We are frozen — except for positions leadership wants.

LIES ABOUT POLITICS & RELATIONSHIPS

31
The Neutrality Lie
I do not play politics — while actively playing.

32
The Backstabbing Lie
Saying one thing to someone's face, another behind their back.

33
The Alliance Lie
I have got your back — until supporting you becomes inconvenient.

34
The Gossip Enablement Lie
Staying silent while someone is trashed.

35
The Favoritism Denial Lie
I treat everyone equally — clearly do not.

LIES ABOUT CULTURE & VALUES

36
The Values Lie
Espousing values that are not rewarded, or are punished.

37
The Authenticity Lie
Bring your whole self — only approved parts.

38
The Psychological Safety Lie
Speak up! — but suffer consequences when you do.

39
The Meritocracy Lie
We promote based on performance — politics matter more.

40
The Diversity Lie
We value different perspectives — as long as they do not challenge us.

LIES ABOUT CHANGE & INITIATIVES

41
The Commitment Lie
We are fully committed to this — until next quarter.

42
The Implementation Lie
We will roll this out properly — underfunded, under-resourced.

43
The Learning Lie
We learn from our mistakes — we repeat them constantly.

44
The Sustainability Lie
This will stick — it is already dying.

45
The Mandate Lie
This came from above — I could push back but will not.

LIES ABOUT PEOPLE & DEPARTURES

46
The Termination Lie
They left for other opportunities — we fired them.

47
The Resignation Lie
It was their choice — we made it unbearable.

48
The Retention Lie
We want to keep you — we are planning your replacement.

49
The Promotion Lie
You are on track — you are actually not being considered.

50
The Succession Lie
You are being groomed for… — we have no intention.

LIES ABOUT MEETINGS & TIME

51
The Meeting Purpose Lie
This will be quick — it will be an hour.

52
The Agenda Lie
Here is what we will cover — the real agenda is hidden.

53
The Decision Meeting Lie
We are here to decide — I am here to get your buy-in.

54
The Update Meeting Lie
Just a quick sync — could have been an email.

55
The Calendar Lie
I am booked solid — I am avoiding you.

LIES OF OMISSION

56
The Silence Lie
Not speaking up when you should.

57
The Withheld Context Lie
Sharing partial information that misleads.

58
The Selective Memory Lie
I do not recall that conversation.

59
The Undiscussable Lie
Everyone knows, no one mentions.

60
The Complicity Lie
Staying silent while lies are told.

These are not character flaws. They are the rational moves inside a system that rewards comfort over truth. Name them. Stop paying for them.